Gap Month

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An Unexpected Visitor

COL-311601

Lobby, Laplace

Hissabeth: Oh, you're here. Perfect. I have something to tell you.

Hissabeth: My transfer request finally went through.

Her formal announcement doesn't receive the reaction she expects, but Hissabeth's excitement is enough for her to overlook the confusion in her colleague's eyes.

Hissabeth: This is the best news I've heard all week! I thought they wouldn't get back to me for months.

Hissabeth: Good thing I didn't wait that long to start clearing up my work.

Hissabeth: Why are you looking at me like that?

Prismagreen: So, you mean you're leaving our project?

Hissabeth: Relax, I'll handle everything. It won't have any ... effects on the research, non?

As the storm clouds gather over her colleague's face, the perceptive Melusine stammers out a compromise.

Hissabeth: You know what? I can finish all my work in three days. Don't worry.

Hissabeth: I can even rebook the ticket a few days sooner. That way ...

Prismagreen: Do things really have to end like this?

Prismagreen is known for her dramatic reactions. Still, the tremble in her voice catches Hissabeth off guard.

Hissabeth: Three days is tight already. I still need time to wrap the buffer material around my biosphere.

Hissabeth: Ah, ça va. Your call. What's our timeframe?

Prismagreen: *cry* If something happened between us that made you want to leave, you could've just told me.

Hissabeth: What's with that look? I thought we were getting along swimmingly.

Hissabeth: We were co-first authors on that paper last month. As far as Laplace is concerned, shared authorship is thicker than blood, n'est-ce pas?

Prismagreen: I just don't understand, darling. If nothing's wrong, I mean if there isn't any bad blood, why would you just up and leave us?

Hissabeth: 'Cause I found a project I'm even more excited about! I've got to say, the direction is amazing. That's why I wanted to tell you right away.

Prismagreen: Sylvie, darling, you ... Ah! My words fail me! How am I supposed to pour out all this sorrow you've poured into my heart?

Hissabeth: Umm. Aren't you happy for me?

The sincerity and confusion in those slit pupils throw Prismagreen into a brief moment of self-doubt amidst her pantomimed sorrow.

Maybe she really did just want to share her good news?

New Office, Plesetsk

Kiperina: I'm so sorry. I can see why you're so upset. It sounds like it really came out of the blue.

Prismagreen: Upset? It felt like someone yanked open my coat on a freezing night and started shoveling snow down my neck!

Pointer: Expecting Hissabeth to act with another's feelings in mind is a lost cause. If you want to keep her around longer, just give her extra tasks. That's more her style anyway.

Prismagreen: Still, when a coworker you got along with suddenly tells you she's leaving—after already filing the paperwork!

Prismagreen: Oh dear, it was just so ... so cold! I couldn't help but be shocked. It hurt.

Kiperina can't help but nod, preemptively heartbroken at the thought of being "abandoned" like that herself.

Pointer: It's Hissabeth. It's well within the parameters of her behavior.

Pointer: She'd slap on a dive helmet and leap into the Mariana Trench if a new project caught her interest down there.

Pointer: In a way, she did try to consider your feelings. She just used the wrong formula to figure them out. Does that make you feel any better?

Prismagreen: Dear, thank you. That's heartwarming. But I know she'd never make that kind of mistake with her actual work.

Hissabeth: I thought I heard my name. Guess we chose the right time to get up.

Hissabeth: That batch of reports from last night nearly did me in ... Hm?

It's not easy to run into an unfamiliar face in Plesetsk, especially not one that feels ... halfway familiar.

Hissabeth: Did you come with the latest delivery from Laplace?

Prismagreen: Oh, my darling Sylvie! My icy little Cornichon! How long has it been?

The sudden warm hug earns a confused look from the sleep-deprived researcher.

Prismagreen: Sylvie?

Hissabeth: Yeah, it's been a while. Still ... you, I see ... uh ...

Time has rusted over memory as she tries to spit out a name. It's familiar, right on the tip of her tongue.

Prismagreen: Oh no! It can't be ... Can it? You've forgotten me? That's just cruel!

Hissabeth: Forgot? No. No, we worked together just before I transferred to Plesetsk. Your name is ...

Hissabeth: Okay. You know I just woke up. Sometimes it takes a second ... any second ...

Luckily, one of her less forgetful siblings jumps in.

Snake VIII: Camille! We'd never forget our most beloved, erudite, and passionate friend!

Snake VIII: Did you ever get around to finishing The Invisible River between experiments? I'm dying to talk about it with you.

The little snake peeks out from Hissabeth's hair and gently curls around the visitor's wrist.

Prismagreen: Aww, why thank you, Estelle. I feel so much better now. Whatever would I do without you?

Hissabeth: Camille? Oh, yes. Yeah, definitely. Of course, Camille. It's so good to see you again.

Prismagreen: I don't even know what there is left to say to you, my cold little Cornichon! I thought we were friends! More than friends ... colleagues!

Prismagreen: Was it not I that was here for you when you first arrived at Laplace HQ—I that helped you during your first project? I came all the way to the Arctic just to see you!

Prismagreen: And you—you can't even remember my name!

A Close Friend

COL-311602

Hissabeth couldn't have truly forgotten her colleague, not her face certainly. Back when she had first joined the LSCC, it was Camille who first helped her sign the contract.

Prismagreen: Here's your contract. Standard clauses, but I recommend giving it a proper read. Researcher Hissabeth, you're a Melusine? That's quite rare.

Hissabeth: My parents say I'm Melusine-blooded. Though honestly, it seems to me we are something closer to a Medusa.

Hissabeth: Ultimately, I decided to just go along with it. They had already filled out the forms before any of us could write.

Prismagreen: I think Melusine sounds much sweeter than a Medusa. There's a legend that Melusines turn into serpents every Saturday—do you do that?

Hissabeth: You've actually heard the legend before? Do you have a favorite version?

Prismagreen: Of course, my dear! There are indeed so many versions, but my preference is for the one that centers on the water nymph, Pressina. As I recall, she agreed to marry a human king under one condition: he must never watch her give birth.

Prismagreen: However, as men so often do, the king broke his vow, and Pressina, ever true to her word, vanished without a trace, leaving behind their three daughters, one of whom was the very first Melusine.

Prismagreen: Their mother, as a final act of cruelty and vengeance, cursed their children to transform into serpents each Saturday.

Prismagreen: Later on, Melusine herself fell in love with another human man. She offered him riches and power, but like her mother, she too had a condition. Every Saturday he was to draw her a bath and then leave her alone from sunrise to sunset.

Hissabeth: This guy didn't live up to his vow either, did he? These stories can be so predictable, n'est-ce pas?

Prismagreen: You're so very right! These tales always seem to follow the same script.

Prismagreen: I think that the intention is a kind of moral lesson—

Prismagreen: A warning against the nature of human curiosity, always stubbornly breaching "boundaries" and prying into "forbidden secrets," and the supernatural punishment that follows.

Prismagreen: Dull and dated, I admit, thematically on-brand for its era.

Snake I: Hey! That interpretation seems a little anthropocentric, don't you think?

Prismagreen: Hmm, who said that?

The interruption of the second voice paints her face with a strange and sudden confusion. Made even more vivid when a third chimes in.

Hissabeth: So, do I sign here?

Prismagreen: Incredible. Do these little snakes have independent consciousness?

Hissabeth: I'm glad my siblings didn't startle you.

Hissabeth: So, I'll just sign here then?

Prismagreen: Oh! Yes, yes. Here on page seven, and the last page as well.

Hissabeth: Page seven? Got it. Give me a sec.

Prismagreen: What a fascinating species! Anyway, allow me to introduce myself again. I'm Prismagreen, I'll be your project lead, though I'd prefer you to think of us as colleagues.

Prismagreen: It's so rare to find someone with real cultural literacy here. At Laplace, it's something far rarer than mere scientific brilliance.

Hissabeth: Glad you think so. But I'm not really the mythology fan in my family. You're looking for my sister.

The mentioned snake pokes her head out from Hissabeth's sleeve.

Snake VIII: That would be me, Estelle. Pleased to meet you!

Hissabeth: I was just reading the contract and overheard your conversation. I didn't mean to interrupt.

Prismagreen: Oh, Estelle, I'm so sorry. I didn't realize ...

The project lead blinks, shifting her eyes down to scan her new colleagues' personnel files again, attempting to make some sense of things.

Prismagreen: So, in total, you're ...?

Snake I: Nine. There's eight of us and one of her. But don't be fooled. I'm Number One around here. She's only Number Two.

Hissabeth: Don't call me by my number.

Snake V: We know, we know. We promised to respect our little Cornichon.

The discordant snake entourage begins to overwhelm Prismagreen, but they're quick to adjust.

Snake I: Why don't we get back to the subject at hand! As I was just saying, it's a human-centric perspective!

Snake I: Why does no one ever try seeing things from Melusine's point of view?

Snake V: Probably because Melusines don't write many academic papers.

Hissabeth is forced to defend herself, or at least her legacy.

Hissabeth: In fact, I've written plenty of papers on behalf of my kind, thank you very much. And they've been published, no less!

Snake V: We know that! But just because you're a genius when it comes to aerospace materials doesn't mean you know jack about literary theory.

Snake VIII: Don't be so negative!

Hissabeth: Ha. Thank you. Maybe one day I'll write a story all about aerospace engineering, then we'll see who's laughing.

Prismagreen: You've always been my favorite, my dear little Estelle. Much nicer than SOME of your siblings.

Prismagreen: Fine, it seems I must reintroduce myself. Perhaps this will ring a bell, Researcher Hissabeth: back when you joined the Laplace HQ, you were part of the fireproofing serpentine ceramic insulation project ...

The project details—like a sponge soaked in cleaner—wipe away the blur that had clouded her memory.

Hissabeth: Oh! I've got it!

Hissabeth: Prismagreen! Oh, I'm sorry. How could I forget you? I do believe I've never met anyone whose arcane skills were more perfectly suited to testing materials than yours!

Hissabeth: You have no idea how much I've missed you since I got here. I still talk about you with Pointer all the time.

Hissabeth: How has that experiment progressed since? I haven't seen any new papers. I was actually thinking of writing to ask.

Her sudden burst of friendly, effortless questions fills the room with an odd warmth, leaving her colleagues puzzling at her.

Prismagreen: Ah, my cold little Cornichon, I'd be happier if you remembered me for more than just my arcane skills.

Hissabeth: In fact, that is the highest compliment I can give.

Their conversation once again veers entirely off-track. Thankfully, someone else chimes in.

Kiperina: Ms. Prismagreen, I'm sure you've come all this way to the Plesetsk Branch for an important reason, right?

Prismagreen: Oh, absolutely. Something very important indeed!

Prismagreen: Look at this. Darling, have you given any thought to switching projects again?

Resort

COL-311603

Prismagreen delivers her invitation with the exact type of direct and forward sensibility she knows appeals to her colleague, yet somehow Hissabeth manages to slip around it.

Hissabeth: What do you mean? A new project? What happened to your old one?

Hissabeth: Is that why you haven't published? Don't tell me it fell apart after I left. It was in great shape back then.

Prismagreen: Of course not. The project is thriving.

Prismagreen: We've found a completely new direction—super low-temperature materials. I do believe our future in that field is as bright as the diamond beaches of Reykjavik.

Prismagreen: I've applied for everything I'd need—staff, funding, labs, equipment, test samples, even vacation time and bonuses!

Hissabeth: In fact, our funding is very tight. So I do wish we had that here.

Hissabeth: I even had to spring for the runium for our teleport disks myself.

Pointer: Thanks for reminding me. You told me to deduct that from your own budget.

Prismagreen: Outrageous! How could Laplace leave such talent to languish without proper funding!

Hissabeth: If you get promoted and be my leader, I believe my supply application will be approved without a hitch.

Prismagreen: I'm not sure that's in my career plan, darling. But I'll try to keep it all in mind.

Prismagreen: As for why I'm here? Isn't it obvious? To take a vacation!

Prismagreen: I've been told by those lovely and always considerate little busybodies in HR that I've gone three years without a vacation. So, I won't be allowed to return to my project until I use up my leave.

Prismagreen: Luckily, just as I was flipping through travel guides, the whole of Laplace began buzzing about you!

Prismagreen: I really couldn't have asked for better timing. Clearly, darling, this is the work of fate:

Prismagreen: A stunning and gorgeous adventure across the far north along with a chance to see a friend and former colleague.

Hissabeth: Okay. So, you're here for a vacation, and seeing me is just a side trip.

Prismagreen: Oh, you mustn't think that, darling.

Hissabeth: I'm no better than you are when it comes to obsessing over work. If I didn't have so much work to do, I'd be happy to show you around.

Snake VIII: I would be more than thrilled to escort Camille on her sightseeing tour!

Hissabeth: Where? There aren't any sights worth seeing that wouldn't keep you away from us too long. It wouldn't be safe.

Prismagreen: Dear, it looks like we're star-crossed for now, but I do thank you both for the thought.

Prismagreen: Before I head out, Sylvie, tell me, will you accept my invitation? I'd be so thrilled for you to join us.

Hissabeth flings her hand out to a nearby bowl of gingerbread, cramming them in her mouth as if to put space between the question and her answer. Unfortunately, her siblings have mouths and minds of their own.

Snake VIII: Ha, great! A chance to work together again. I wouldn't dream of passing that up, Camille!

Snake VIII: It's been so long since I've had someone to talk literature with; there's no appreciation for poetry up here. No one to chat to about Eliot and Pound ... Sometimes I think I'd just be better off brumating.

Pointer eyes the complaining snake, musing over what emotion she ought to feel.

Pointer: Is it really so bad here, Hissabeth? I could recite more poems to you, if you'd like.

Hissabeth: *gulp* No, no, please no. I prefer more efficient modes of communication.

Snake I: It doesn't matter much to me either way, only ... did you say you've gotten full funding?

Prismagreen: Naturally, darling. We're a top-tier team in the internal priority rankings.

Snake V: That kind of backing is dangerously tempting. N'est pas, little Cornichon?

But Hissabeth has preemptively deployed another bite of gingerbread, offering only a strained and unclear response.

Prismagreen: Dear, please, oh please. Won't you consider it, Sylvie? You've already accomplished the impossible here, and all of Laplace is singing your praises.

Prismagreen: Your dream has come true. Now, with me, you could begin a brand new chapter, a new dream for us both. I can't think of a single reason for you to turn me down, darling.

Hissabeth: Okay, I'll hear you out. I assume you've brought the project proposal?

Prismagreen: Now?

Hissabeth: The sooner, the better.

Hissabeth: I can give you an hour. If we move quickly, we could start discussing your new project in half that time.

Prismagreen: There's really no need to rush things, darling. We'll have plenty of time to get you up to speed on the project while I'm enjoying the sights here.

Hissabeth: In fact, Camille, I didn't say that I'd accept—only that I'd consider it. So, why not tell me now?

Prismagreen gives a discontented huff as she dumps her travel bag onto the table. Somewhere between mounds of fleece scarves and earmuffs, she finds her proposal.

Prismagreen: Very well, darling. Read through this first, then come find me. But don't forget—I'm here on a wonderful whirlwind vacation. Now would any of you dears be so good as to tell me where I might see the aurora, or what was it—the ice plains?

Laplace Branch Hallway

Hissabeth takes the document and leaves her colleagues, new and old, behind as they chat about directions and forecasts.

Snake I: You know what, Two ...

Snake V: Yeah, what's up? I've got a feeling you weren't really craving three handfuls of gingerbread.

Snake VIII: Come on! Just accept the invitation, Sylvie. I don't see why you're hesitating!

Hissabeth: Ha. You don't?

Snake VI: Camille thinks we've already reached our dreams, but we've only answered one question. All our work so far has barely even brushed the edge of the cosmos.

Hissabeth: Always on cue, Monique.

Hissabeth: I thought we all agreed that this is our shared dream.

Snake V: Yes, we did. But still, shouldn't we take some time to pause and reflect?

Snake I: Five's right! Reflection, course correction—that's the best kind of relaxation after wrapping a project.

Hissabeth: Okay. You imply that a course correction is necessary.

[English text unavailable]

COL-311604

Snake VIII: You're always so resolute, sister.

Snake VIII: The narrow tightrope ahead of us is shrouded in an inscrutable fog. Unless we walk it, blind to fate, how can we know we've made the right decision?

Hissabeth: Just give it a try.

It's common knowledge: nothing bridges distance faster than talking about a mutual friend.

Prismagreen: Dear, I must say, you seem a much better match for Sylvie than I was.

Prismagreen: She's always found fault with my poetic turns of phrase; she suggested I was too theatrical. Can you believe that? Theatrical? Me?

Prismagreen: As much as I care for her, she can be so unfeeling, wouldn't you agree?

Pointer takes a moment to calculate.

Pointer: She's well within acceptable parameters.

Pointer: We have had our disagreements. But I've always found Hissabeth to be straight to the point and dedicated to her work, sometimes dangerously so.

Prismagreen: Okay. More's the pity. You two really are a fine match.

Prismagreen: Darling, be honest with me: do you think there's any chance she'll say yes?

Pointer: What?

Prismagreen: To my invitation.

Prismagreen: Dear, it seems you have a much deeper insight into her mind than I ever had. Tell me, please, what do you think she'll do?

The pause is longer this time. The computations growing even more complex.

Pointer: Hissabeth is highly perceptive when it comes to interpreting new data on both its costs and benefits. In this, we are very alike.

Pointer: My analysis would suggest that she would find any proposal on such generous terms to be enticing.

Prismagreen: But, what if it isn't her preferred field?

Lacking any modeling to analyze this question, she offers only a very human shrug.

What the Snake Said

COL-311605

Family Meeting, Hissabeth's Mind

Hissabeth: So, our meeting today has been called to discuss our possible transfer. The Laplace Office in Plesetsk is offering us a role in an aerospace-related research project.

Hissabeth: Our project would be to develop teleportation disks capable of delivering supplies to spacecraft. What could be a more perfect fusion of arcanum and science? This has the potential to be exactly what we're looking for.

Hissabeth: The floor is open; let's hear everyone's thoughts.

Snake III: Hisssss—

Hissabeth: As usual, Cephnest abstains. Anyone else?

Snake I: I think you're overstating things; it's only tangentially related to our targeted field.

Snake VI: But it is related! It's just like eating a fish; you've got to go bite-by-bite.

Her unusual metaphor fails to clarify things—and the topic derails.

Snake V: I told you those fish in the eco-tank were Six's doing!

Snake VI: It wasn't me—it was Cephnest. Probably training his hunting skills again.

Hissabeth: All discussion of the "eco-tank incident" can wait. Back on track—Monique's point is what I wanted to highlight.

Hissabeth: We'll begin with just working on transporting supplies into orbit, sure. But that's just the beginning; with time, we may be able to teleport people there too.

A tail tip rises. The siblings pride themselves on being fully informed before taking sides.

Snake VII: Sorry I was out cold all last week. Would someone kindly tell me where Plesetsk is?

Hissabeth: In simple terms, it's a little north of Moscow, give or take 500 miles.

Snake I: It's in the Arctic Circle! One gust and we're popsicles! Ice everywhere—very exciting!

A vivid description. Irrefutable, and for many, visibly unpleasant. Hissabeth attempts to salvage Plesetsk's image.

Hissabeth: The research is all indoors. In a climate-controlled office.

Snake III: *hiss*

Snake V: Sounds like Cephnest isn't a fan.

Snake VIII: The Arctic Circle? Sounds like an adventure! What could possibly be better?

Hissabeth: Let's wrap this up.

[English text unavailable]

COL-311606

Hissabeth wakes from her dream, neck stiff as she looks down at the scattered project notes that fell from her hand.

Hissabeth: Clearly I need some sleep. What a weird thing to dream of now.

Snake I: Is it? Or maybe your subconscious is reminding you: it's time for another formal vote.

Usually her siblings were kind enough not to intrude into her dreams—usually.

Hissabeth: You really are a sneak. Fine, are we going to hold another meeting?

Snake V: Honestly, I don't see a reason to turn her down.

Hissabeth: You mean concerning Prismagreen's proposal—

Hissabeth: Okay. I admit the project files are interesting, but it's not exactly cutting-edge research. It's focused and entirely practical refinement.

Snake VI: I think our current project's near-shutdown should be added to our risk assessment. I doubt it'll be the last.

Hissabeth: Abandoning a project over a few problems isn't our way.

Snake VIII: Starlight doesn't always have to light our way, Sylvie. Sometimes we can look elsewhere.

Snake VI: Seems like we're far from a consensus this time around.

It's a position that is far from unusual for these siblings.

Hissabeth: In fact, pushing for a conclusion without consensus doesn't help.

Hissabeth: Let's just unwind a little first and gather our thoughts, maybe find something to eat. I propose we delay our decision until the next meeting.

The grumbling stomachs make for a quick decision, and the motion passes unanimously.

Restaurant, Town

When you work in a place with too few restaurants, you're bound to bump into familiar faces.

Kiperina: Oh, Miss Hissabeth, what a surprise.

Hissabeth: Considering the lack of quality restaurants in this area and our shared love of food, I'd hardly call it too surprising.

Hissabeth: Kidding. Just kidding. It's all good, kiddo. You being here just means we can order more!

Hissabeth: The stewed beef looks good. Or is there something you wanted to try?

Kiperina: Sure, I'd like to try the beef. If you'd like to, I mean.

Hissabeth: Then let's do that, plus one of these and a couple of those cookies I like. Thank you.

Restaurant Owner: Absolutely, girls. Old Yuri will make sure you leave full and happy.

Hissabeth: So, have you heard anything from Windsong? After what you've been through, I thought she'd have gotten you in another position real quick.

Kiperina: She said the same. But I guess she received some sudden news. She said she had to go somewhere to "lend a hand."

Kiperina: So I'm still here for now, at least until she returns. What about you?

Hissabeth: Me?

Kiperina: I just mean, did you decide anything yet?

Restaurant Owner: Here's your toast and cream fish soup. Eat up, girls.

Kiperina: Oh, it looks delicious, Mr. Yuri! Thank you!

Restaurant Owner: It's Old Yuri's best dish. Don't forget to dip the bread.

The ever-striving little astronaut can't help but nod and follow out his suggestion.

Kiperina: Hmm! It's really good!

Old Yuri walks off, satisfied with the praise.

Hissabeth: Everything's changing so fast. It's comforting when something still tastes the same.

Hissabeth glances over. Kiperina is gently stirring the soup, lost in thought. Changing soup flavors had been the least of her worries.

Hissabeth: Hey, uhm, maybe I can offer some emotional support?

Kiperina: But, I wasn't ... Uh, I mean, thank you.

She sees the quiet hope in the eyes looking back at her.

Hissabeth: In fact, all the stars we see are really billions of light-years away.

Hissabeth: By the time we finally get to see it, the star it's from may have already collapsed.

Hissabeth: But it's still there for you to see, and its light will keep on traveling forever.

Kiperina: Oh. That's really kind of poetic.

Hissabeth: Maybe it is. It's almost poetic, isn't it? The light in your eyes, your memory of that star—your very existence is someone else's legacy.

Hissabeth: So don't be too sad. You'll carry them forward, just like they carried you.

Kiperina: Thank you, Miss Hissabeth. I ... I guess I'm just not used to all these changes.

Kiperina: But I'll try my best to hold them in my memory. I know that's what they'd want.

Hissabeth nods with some satisfaction, filing the moment away in her memory.

Next time someone accuses her of being "distant," she'll have solid evidence to the contrary.

She turns her attention back to her soup, until Kiperina's soft laughter scoops her up again.

Kiperina: I guess I'm just surprised to hear you say all that; I remember when you told us you were "allergic to poetry."

Snake I: Our shared consciousness means that if I'm reading Chaucer and Two is reading about general relativity, all nine of us gain a measure of both.

Maxim had been holding back for a while to preserve the atmosphere Hissabeth had carefully constructed. Now it found the perfect opening and struck.

Hissabeth: It's extremely efficient. Even Pointer is envious of our ability to analyze data so fast. Still, we have our own passions; I've never really liked literature or philosophy much.

Hissabeth: Though I wasn't really being serious back then. I do like poetry—a little, in small doses.

Hissabeth: It can be an effective tool for mental training—analyzing the layers of imagery, tone, and emotion can be useful for sharpening one's logical faculties.

Snake VIII: Ugh, Sylvie! Do you really have to reduce it to a science? Poetry is the crowning glory of civilization.

Hissabeth: Didn't one of your favorite writers once say that one illiterate person could humble any writer? Something like that. Well I can read, but ...

Hissabeth: Oh, who was it ... Eliot? Or maybe Whitman? One of them anyway; I think he'd appreciate my point of view.

However Eliot or Whitman would have reacted, it's abundantly clear someone else is not pleased right now.

Hissabeth: Ah!

Snake I: Ouf! Eight, why did you bite her?

Snake VIII: You know why!

Snake V: Imbécile! Did you forget that we'd all feel it?

Snake IV: Huh ... What just happened?

Such sudden family conflicts are rare and usually don't turn to biting. Kiperina reactively began separating them from one another.

In the process, she missed the perfect moment to ask her question.

Yet a hint of curiosity lingers in her mind.

Kiperina: Speaking of which, will you accept Miss Prismagreen's invitation?

The Proof in the Pudding

COL-311607

Hissabeth: So, let's return to the topic of our last meeting: do we join Prismagreen's new project, or stick with our own?

Snake V: What is our current project again?

Hissabeth: Space. Stars. Everything Voyager 1 encountered beyond our atmosphere.

Snake VI: Have we finally finished our research proposal?

Hissabeth: No, I think it still needs work.

Snake VIII: Camille's proposal has already passed Laplace review.

Snake VIII: Nailing down a new research direction isn't easy; these things can take time. Why not check out Camille's plan first?

As if struck by inspiration, Hissabeth claps her hands.

Hissabeth: You know what? Estelle, you're right. We should go to headquarters. Why not?

Hissabeth: Evaluate first, decide later. We've saved up enough vacation days.

Snake I: Awesome! A field trip and a scouting mission—maybe even fully expensed!

Hissabeth: I do love an expense report. All right, let's vote.

[English text unavailable]

COL-311608

Pointer: I wanted to talk to you about—

Pointer pauses to re-examine her optic feedback as it becomes clear the girl holding the snake is not who she thought.

Pointer: Oh, I thought you were Hissabeth.

Snake VI: Sylvie was up all night talking with Prismagreen. I suspect you won't see either of them this morning.

Snake VI: Thanks again, sweetheart. I'll be off now.

Kiperina: Shall I walk you out?

The snake flicks its tail, declining the offer, and vanishes through the door.

Kiperina: I was just helping Monique feed the fish.

The thoughtful girl gave a very short explanation so Pointer could understand her easily. Then, she couldn't help but murmur out the thoughts racing through her head:

Kiperina: Speaking of which, if Miss Hissabeth really does decide to join Prismagreen, she'll probably take the eco-tank with her, won't she?

Pointer: It's a logical deduction. I certainly won't be feeding them in her absence.

Kiperina: I was just thinking ...

Pointer: Don't get too sentimental. Once you and Windsong are back at HQ, you'll probably see her again.

Pointer: Though, knowing her, I doubt she'll stay there long.

Kiperina: If—just if—Miss Hissabeth decides to accept ...

Pointer: Then it will be her choice.

The other shoe drops, louder and sooner than anyone expected.

Hissabeth: Ah, good you're both here. I've arranged with Prismagreen to head back to Laplace HQ. Remember to feed the fish.

Pointer & Kiperina: ...

Hissabeth: ...?

Hissabeth: What's with that look?

Seeing her confusion is genuine, Pointer decides to answer in plain terms.

Pointer: We'll remember.

Office, Laplace Branch

Hissabeth has never been troubled by packing. After all, she has eight helpers.

Hissabeth: Leave that. And that too. We're only going on vacation.

Snake VIII: Oh, but I haven't finished that one yet!

Hissabeth: I'm the one that needs to lug them around. Three books, max.

Snake VIII: Sylvie, my darling sister—five? Just five, come on, please?

Hissabeth: Is it just me, or are you starting to sound exactly like Prismagreen?

Pointer: Can I ... come in?

Hissabeth: Yeah. Door's open for you anytime.

Pointer: Thanks. I had noticed.

Pointer: I was hoping to talk about those shelved research plans, but I guess this isn't the best time?

Hissabeth: Actually, I wanted to talk to you about that too.

Hissabeth: This place is a mess. Can you grab that folder for me? The gray one.

Pointer: Aha, so this is going to be your next pursuit.

Hissabeth: Given the context of aerospace applications, protective measures are obviously crucial.

Pointer: A good angle. But as a research topic, it could use more refinement.

Pointer scans the document in her hand in a series of careful and precise eye movements, putting the conversation on hold.

Hissabeth: Take your time. No need to rush to think up your constructive criticism. I'm sure you'll get it to me before I leave.

The word "leave" triggers something deep in Pointer's circuitry.

Pointer: I hadn't predicted that you would go. Just like that. Aren't you concerned about personality clashes? As I recall, Ms. Prismagreen said you had a serious argument the last time you announced your departure.

Hissabeth: Oh, that. I wouldn't call it an argument. I simply didn't agree to her proposals. She has a habit of blowing things out of proportion.

Hissabeth: And the success of our research here proves I made the right choice.

Pointer: Respectfully, I disagree.

Pointer: Of course, I can't deny our success here, but your decision was reckless. Luck and probability played a significant role in your success.

Pointer: I don't regret trying to talk you out of it. Even if you got lucky.

Hissabeth: Has there ever been a scientific endeavor that didn't rely on a little luck and probability? All that I care about is that we succeeded.

Pointer: That's the problem—that's entirely the problem, Hissabeth. I had hoped you'd given your decisions a more sober analysis during our wind-down.

A gentle voice slips in between the two gradually rising ones.

Kiperina: Ma'am—

The not-quite-closed door creaks open again. The girl peeking in looks as if she's about to step out on a tightrope.

Kiperina: The door wasn't shut. I ... Do you need any help?

Hissabeth & Pointer: No, we're fine.

The synchronized nature of their reply seems to only highlight their tension. Still their intruder doesn't press.

Kiperina: Would you like me to close the door?

Hissabeth & Pointer: Thank you.

The click of the lock begins a long silence.

Calculations and meditations on both sides seem destined to break.

Pointer: Take a look at this when you have time.

Hissabeth: What's this?

Hissabeth: What an interesting concept. I'm glad you've been keeping busy too.

Hissabeth flips through eagerly, sparks flying between her eyes and the pages.

Hissabeth: Just this line alone could keep us talking for three days straight!

Hissabeth: But I'm leaving tomorrow. But it's cool. We can always exchange letters!

Weightless Wasteland

COL-311609

What makes a perfect vacation?

Entertainment? Depends on the person. A change of scenery? Not everyone craves that. Local delicacies? Oh yes, the more the better.

Hissabeth: One more raspberry panna cotta, please, and a puff pastry chicken soup with pumpkin.

Prismagreen: I'm ever so glad to see your appetite's as strong as ever, Sylvie.

Hissabeth: The food at HQ blows the rest of the branches right out of the water.

Prismagreen: Too bad most researchers here know nothing about how to enjoy a good meal. You know I've heard they're working on making a condensed nutrition pill? What a dreadful idea, darling.

Hissabeth: Eh, non. I can see it being quite convenient. Just hope they remember to make it taste decent.

Prismagreen: Well, you can count me right out. I'll stick to something real.

Hissabeth: I'm tempted to order another dessert. What do you think?

Prismagreen: None for me. But please, enjoy your afternoon tea. This one's on me, remember.

Hissabeth: Merci, Camille. What a fulfilling vacation—great food and even better research. I feel amazing.

Prismagreen: So is that it then ... You really only came here for a vacation?

Hissabeth: Is something wrong?

Prismagreen: It's just that you ... Never mind. I'll get used to it.

Prismagreen: That experimental design you pitched last night was brilliant. You really are the perfect fit. Your joining this "vacation," no matter how long it lasts, will boost our productivity tenfold!

Prismagreen: But—have you decided, darling? For the sake of me, of anything, even just the puff pastry and the chefs here—won't you stay?

Her earnest, heartfelt invitation pulls Hissabeth's attention back from her dessert.

Hissabeth: Your project is fantastic, truly. You know I'm not one for flattery; helping out with your work here has really given me what I needed to sort out my thoughts.

The praise sets the stage. Her voice softens, and with it Prismagreen's face falls.

Prismagreen: You're about to say "but," aren't you? Oh no, dear, my heart's already too cracked. How could Laplace ever handle it if I went through another heartbreak?

She covers her ears as a futile protest, knowing full well that she's never once managed to stop Hissabeth from doing anything that she'd decided on.

Hissabeth: Don't be childish, Camille. I know you're listening.

Hissabeth: I am grateful for your invitation, and I truly believe in your project's future. But it's not aligned with the direction I want to pursue.

Prismagreen: I don't accept that because, well, because I don't understand!

Hissabeth: *sigh* You always say that.

Hissabeth: This time, I don't intend to offer any opinions or suggestions. I'm letting you know my decision. You can decide for yourself whether or not you'll understand.

Prismagreen: I know, I know I shouldn't pry, but I have to. Why bother? So you launch a record, or a spacecraft, or even a person into space ... what's the point of it all?

Prismagreen: Dear, the stars are just too far away.

Prismagreen: By the time our poor little eyes witness their birth, they may have already collapsed in on themselves or faded away into nothing.

Hissabeth: This is why we always find ourselves disagreeing, Prismagreen. You can't help but inject all this drama and poetry into matters of science.

They both stop mid-argument, right as it was about to crescendo. Two old friends, locking eyes, gripped by the unmistakable feeling of déjà vu.

Prismagreen: *cry* If something happened between us that made you want to leave, you could've just told me.

Hissabeth: I thought we were getting along swimmingly.

Hissabeth: I'm just more interested in this new project. The fusion of arcanum and science, aerospace frontier applications—every part of it speaks to our goals as a researcher.

Prismagreen: It's a fringe project. It's doubtful you'll have any kind of team or secure any serious funding—

Prismagreen: Dear Sylvie, you must understand: Laplace brushing it off is a sign in itself.

Prismagreen: Our serpentine ceramic paper is about to be published. Think of the real-world applications, darling! With your talent, we could go so far down this path together.

Hissabeth: So what?

Hissabeth: So maybe we've got a knack for making ceramic materials. But we're more than that. It doesn't need to define us.

Hissabeth: I'm proud of what we've achieved here, but I want to pursue other goals—the things that really matter to me.

Hissabeth: I know it may seem hard to accept, but my talents and my passions don't perfectly align. When it comes down to it, we've chosen to pursue what is most important to us.

Prismagreen: But what you're chasing is a life devoted to a barren, weightless void. It may seem like the future, but there's no life in it. Nothing can survive up there, darling. It's just idle curiosity and wasted effort.

Prismagreen: I just don't see how you can be so fixated on something that has no practical purpose.

Hissabeth: Why is curiosity not enough? Evolution preserved this instinct in us so thoroughly and powerfully that it must hold some essential meaning.

Hissabeth: Ultimately, I don't care whether you think of it as the natural drive of evolution or something as hokey as a higher calling. No one survives forever, not in space and not on earth, Prismagreen, but before our end arrives, we're going to live on our terms.

Prismagreen: From someone of your age, some might call that a childish act of rebellion.

Hissabeth: And from someone with your tone, some might call that a snide personal attack.

Prismagreen: I'm sorry, Sylvie. I didn't mean to attack you. I just—

Prismagreen: Dear, the stars are just too far away.

Prismagreen: In ancient poems, I should be the one guiding you back into the fold. As your mentor, I have to insist—your brilliance doesn't belong in devotion to dead starlight.

Hissabeth: Then, if I know anything about literature, I have to insist on my part, too. Rejecting the call. If you need some poetic reason, then imagine me as some dust-eating serpent yearning for the sky and, beyond it, something higher still.

Hissabeth: Where did Voyager 1 end up? Where did the Golden Record go? After Earth, where else can we go?

Hissabeth: Every one of those "wheres" matters to me. That weightless wasteland—and every star in it—they all matter to me.

Hissabeth: And I don't need anyone else's recognition.

Clearly, they both see in each other's eyes a shared memory.

Prismagreen & Hissabeth: ...

The smiles after that silence carry more than nostalgia. There's a quiet recognition that neither of them has changed.

Time hasn't moved either side an inch, and with that understanding, further debate is pointless.

Hissabeth: So you still think I shouldn't "waste my brilliance" on "dead starlight"?

Prismagreen: You never quite convinced me back then, darling. If not for the idealistic glow in your eyes, I might've pushed harder.

Hissabeth: I had an idealistic glow? Really?

Prismagreen: Oh, don't fuss over glows. All I meant then, as I do now, is that you're always welcome here. I'll keep a desk open for you.

Hissabeth: Not gonna lie, when they told me the disk project was getting scrapped, we did take some comfort in knowing it was there.

Prismagreen: I truly never expected you to pull it off, let alone so spectacularly.

Hissabeth: Don't sugarcoat it, you still think it was a big waste of time.

Prismagreen: Call me a traditionalist, dear. Still, I hoped that after that first taste of glory you'd come back down to earth.

Hissabeth: Too bad, then. The universe is vast; the stars are beyond counting. I'll be up there looking at them for a long time coming.

Prismagreen: See? That right there—that blinding glow you get!

Prismagreen: Very well. Looks like I'm destined to drown in another flood of resumes.

Prismagreen: In every version of the story, Melusine always repeats Pressina's fate. Maybe you've inherited more than just a talent for transmutation.

Prismagreen: The legendary Lusignan was built in a single night, but Melusine was never the architect.

Prismagreen: Over the years, I did try following your advice, thinking from a "Melusine-centrism" perspective.

Snake VIII: Please allow me to interrupt. I very much want to hear your "Melusine-centrism" literary critique!

Prismagreen: Of course, dear Estelle. And you, too—my dear cold-hearted little Cornichon.

Prismagreen: Let me interpret the legend from Melusine's point of view: a miracle is kept by one's word—that's the true core of the story.

Prismagreen: I sincerely wish you the best of luck, my dearest Sylvie.

Hissabeth: Merci, Camille. I hope the same for you.

Prismagreen: Though I'm afraid this means I won't be able to promise you an open desk any longer. With your help, this project is even more popular than ever—I've got applications piling up.

Hissabeth: I have to say, that was some world-class showing off.

Family Meeting, Hissabeth's Mind

As agreed, the family of snakes gathers once more to discuss their plans at the end of their vacation.

Snake I: Honestly, Two, I've got nothing against chasing stars and the cutting edge of science, but does it have to be Plesetsk?

Snake VIII: Still, I must admit I'm heartbroken over it. You know how much I cared for Camille.

Snake VI: Pointer's new research proposal really convinced me. We should be able to secure a decent budget this time, right?

Hissabeth: I actually agree with you, Maxim.

The unexpected opening line quiets the snakes for a moment.

Snake III: Hiss hiss?

Snake I: You nearly startled Three into speaking! Bien sûr, my points are always solid. But uhm, what is it that you agree with?

Hissabeth: I would like to revise today's agenda. If there's no immediate launch planned, I propose we relocate the Plesetsk research project back to HQ.

Cognitive Bias

COL-311610

Lobby, Laplace

Though a bit regretful, Estelle is still pleased with her trip. Particularly because she finally has time to discuss her favorite topic to her heart's content.

Snake VIII: Ever since humanity created literature, snakes have always been tied to curses.

Snake VIII: From the dust-eating serpent of Eden to the Epic of Gilgamesh, even the Melusine legend is like that.

Snake VIII: Sometimes this terribly anthropocentric view makes me so mad I want to give up literature altogether.

Prismagreen: You really must talk to Ulrich, my sweet little pumpkin. I remember he spent his vacation in your office recently?

Prismagreen: He's one of Laplace's most outspoken anti-anthropocentrism theorists.

Snake VIII: Really? Too bad I didn't get the chance to meet him.

Snake I: Two was barely touching the ground those days. But more importantly—

Snake V: You were brumating.

Snake I: Not that it's any big loss. He didn't seem like the literary type.

Snake V: But he might know a thing or two about fish tanks. His setup looked way better than little Cornichon's.

Just as the snakes begin to enjoy their chat, Hissabeth starts picking them up one by one, placing them back on her head.

Hissabeth: I will remember to write Ulrich about eco-tank material compositions. Maybe he has a recommended formula.

Prismagreen: Parting brings such sorrow, my dear Sylvie. Are you really leaving again?

Prismagreen: I've prepared a gift for you—a few of your favorite snacks that I know you can never find up there ... oh, and this.

Prismagreen: My grandmother's handwritten recipe book. May you always have a healthy appetite.

Hissabeth: That's fantastic! Would you mind if I gave it to the canteen chef? You know I don't cook much myself.

Prismagreen: As you wish, darling. My grandmother was a kind and generous woman. I'm sure she wouldn't mind.

Prismagreen: I also prepared a long poem as a farewell. Shall I recite it for you now?

Hissabeth: Oh? Well, I really don't have much time. Besides—

Prismagreen: Of course, darling! I know you're not a fan of lengthy texts. Don't worry. I've prepared a condensed version just for you.

Hissabeth opens her mouth, but Prismagreen cuts her off with a theatrical gesture and clears her throat.

Prismagreen: Dear Sylvie, I must, once again, bid you a tearful farewell.

Prismagreen: I know that for my kind, it is difficult to imagine life from the eyes of a Melusine.

Prismagreen: But as a friend and, I hope you'll allow me to say this, as a mentor, I offer you all my respect and support.

Prismagreen: May your talent and vision shake Laplace once more.

Hissabeth: Parfait! I appreciate you condensing it down. It's beautiful, Camille.

Her overly cheerful tone breaks the slightly melancholic farewell mood and leaves Prismagreen's carefully built-up emotions crashing down.

Prismagreen: What?

Hissabeth: Oh, not the part about "shaking Laplace," that's not important.

Hissabeth: We came up with a brilliant idea last night. You're going to love it.

Hissabeth: Even if you don't, I'd still like all your respect and support. Those were your exact words just now.

Prismagreen: Hmm? I ... Yes, I did say that.

For some reason, Prismagreen suddenly regrets her earlier declaration.

But Hissabeth is full of enthusiasm. She's certain her friend will be a huge help.

New Office, Plesetsk

While feeding the fish in the morning, Kiperina hears from Pointer that the tank's owner has officially ended her vacation and will soon resume her feeding duties.

But the girl doesn't expect the path back to her friend to be completely blocked by moving boxes.

Kiperina: Miss Hissabeth, I just heard you've come back. Is everything going smoothly?

Hissabeth: Certainement. Smooth as can be.

Two little snakes drag a heavy box across the floor, and the kindhearted girl steps in to offer her help.

Kiperina: I used to carry props around all the time when I was with the circus.

Hissabeth: Thanks so much, Alia. Moving is a big operation. These samples and materials all need to be packed properly.

Hissabeth: If only we could move house using the teleport disk. Maybe one day. You think we could spin that into a new funding pitch—uh, I mean, proposal?

Pointer: If I understand you correctly, then what you're talking about was in fact our original purpose.

It seems her colleague is more than happy to snuff out Hissabeth's spark of hope from the moment she walks in.

Kiperina: So then you're heading back to the LSCC HQ, Miss Hissabeth?

Hissabeth: That's one way to put it. Don't touch that, Maxim! That one needs special containment.

Snake I: No need to shout. You'll startle the others.

Pointer watches the busy scene unfolding in the room and calculates the obvious conclusion.

Pointer: Looks like I'm not really needed here.

Pointer: In that case, I'll head back and get on with my own work.

Hissabeth: Oh, of course. I've got this all handled.

Kiperina can't help but join in the moving operation. Handled or not.

Kiperina: Wait, Miss Pointer—

The girl catches up, still clutching a box she hadn't had time to put down.

Pointer: Yes?

Kiperina: Aren't you going to do something? Like, maybe, try to keep her here?

Pointer: You mean Hissabeth? Why would I?

Kiperina: I just thought you two would keep working together. There's still so much unfinished work to do before the project reaches space again.

Pointer: There is.

Pointer: But Prismagreen's project is also excellent. Laplace doesn't give out top ratings lightly.

Kiperina: Then what do you plan to do?

Like with the boxes before, Kiperina feels compelled to help, even if she isn't quite sure how.

Pointer: Me? I intend to keep progressing our research and refining this proposal.

Scanning the girl's expression, Pointer eventually comes to a more human understanding.

Pointer: You don't have to worry about me, Alia. I was working on this project alone long before Hissabeth came.

Pointer: I predict that things will slow down without her assistance, but I'm certain we will still be able to correspond from time to time.

Kiperina: Are you ... sure?

Pointer: Within tolerances. But the point is.

Pointer brushes back her hair. The mechanical structure hums in precise motion—orderly, self-contained.

Pointer: No one can change her mind. If that's what she wants to do, she'll do it.

Au revoir, chers amis

COL-311611

Pointer sits at her desk, going about her work as usual.

Hissabeth: Hello.

Pointer: Come in.

Hissabeth surveys the room, an unreadable flicker of dissatisfaction in her gaze, leaving Pointer a bit puzzled.

Hissabeth: You haven't started, have you?

Pointer: What?

Hissabeth: D'accord. Fine, once I finish things up on my end, we'll help you pack too.

Hissabeth: But for now, come take a look at this.

Pointer: What ...

Pointer: You've made a lot of revisions.

Hissabeth: Even though you never wrote back to discuss, I filled in the gaps, including the materials I showed you earlier.

Pointer: This low-temp materials testing angle ... Was this inspired by Prismagreen? This has the potential to dramatically improve our project's outcomes.

Hissabeth: Looks good, right? The Laplace review panel thinks so too.

Pointer: Thank you, Researcher Hissabeth.

Pointer: Don't worry. I'll make sure to list you as a corresponding author when we submit.

Getting the proposal updated was a pleasant surprise. Pointer smiles contentedly as she imagines yet another well-received paper.

Yet somehow her colleague doesn't seem pleased.

Hissabeth: The corresponding author?!

Hissabeth: Why?!

Several small snakes peek out from her hair. Pointer has seen it before, a sign of great emotional disturbance.

Pointer: Well, it's going to be my project, after all? Since you're about to transfer to Laplace HQ and join another team?

Hissabeth: Another team? There is no other team. This is my project. Our project. The one I'm about to start working on!

Her serpentine siblings flick their tongues, eager to join in before Hissabeth at least realizes the crucial piece of missing context.

Hissabeth: You don't know? Incroyable! I thought they already informed you!

Pointer: I haven't received any information at all. So, go ahead, I guess.

The siblings all seem to collectively relax, falling down limply as Hissabeth smiles.

Hissabeth: After I completed our proposal, I submitted it to HQ as a brand-new project.

Hissabeth: It passed the review! What is it that you think I'm packing?

Pointer: Our proposal?

Hissabeth: Correct. You're listed as my co-applicant.

Pointer's eyes shift as she takes in, piece by piece, the information that Hissabeth is relaying.

Hissabeth: We even got a collaboration invite from Prismagreen's team—secured additional funding for joint development. It all came in within our main budget.

Pointer: So you're packing because ...

Hissabeth: I requested an office at HQ. We'll need to work there for a while, to get the joint budget.

Hissabeth: They've got all the equipment there that we could ever need but could never get all the way up here.

Pointer: You make an excellent argument.

Pointer: Aside from the part where I somehow knew none of this.

Hissabeth: Chill, Pointer. Knowing now is good enough.

Hissabeth waves her off breezily. Pointer doesn't move, doesn't speak, doesn't blink. After ten seconds of sustained eye contact, Hissabeth adjusts her tone.

Hissabeth: Alright, alright, I admit it was a little irresponsible. I just thought the HQ notice would reach you before I did.

Pointer: I believe they likely assumed you already told me. You know, because it would be crazy not to.

Hissabeth: Ah, but then there'd be no surprise! Maybe the paper notice is still on its way? Or worse—stuck in some admin's typewriter.

They usually bonded over shared complaints about Laplace bureaucracy. It's a good topic to eliminate awkward atmospheres.

Hissabeth: Anyway, co-first author is my bottom line. So, you're coming, right?

Hissabeth: I even applied for your budget, your stipend, your office, and your lab. If you say no now ...

Pointer: Well then. What else can I say? I'm in.

No more discussion is needed. They shift immediately into planning the relocation—smooth and efficient as always.

Restaurant, Town

Their celebration dinner is smaller than intended, but no less high-spirited.

Hissabeth: Name Day's off on a mission, Windsong hasn't returned, Han Zhang left a note saying he's off doing side work, and Voyager's reassignment to the HQ team just got extended again.

Hissabeth: Glad you're still here, Alia. Otherwise it'd just be us two eating by ourselves.

Snake V: That'd be us nine and Pointer, wouldn't it?

Kiperina: It's an honor, ma'am.

The girl lifts her glass of juice with great sincerity and clinks glasses with each of them.

Hissabeth: We first met here too, didn't we? I think we even ordered the same dishes.

Snake I: That's what happens when so much has happened. Time feels fast and slow all at once!

Kiperina: So then, this will be the last time we eat together here?

She glances around the still oddly familiar restaurant; despite her tone, she knows it isn't a question.

Pointer: If our research ever makes it to the flight launch phase, we'll be back.

Hissabeth: Laplace works with a lot of launch centers. But Prismagreen really likes it here. She says the snowfields and auroras feel poetic.

Hissabeth: Considering how closely our teams are collaborating, she might find an excuse to drag us back here.

Pointer: I have no objections.

Hissabeth: Same here.

Hissabeth: Oh! Almost forgot—I should be offering Alia some emotional support now. Let me think.

She grows serious, making an exaggerated effort to engage the unused synapses of her shared mind as the snakes whisper their suggestions.

Pointer: Emotional support? Is this part of some new research project?

Hissabeth: Prismagreen said I'm terrible at giving emotional support to my colleagues, but I like to think I'm doing a decent job.

Hissabeth: Right, Alia?

Kiperina smiles as best as she can. She hates to let others down. So, she gives a stellar performance.

Kiperina: Thank you, Miss Hissabeth. Really, I'm fine. I don't need any special comfort or encouragement.

Hissabeth: Mais non, but I need more success cases. You know what they say. Only samples over thirty are statistically significant.

Pointer: I don't know what happened last time, and I don't want to, but I suggest you stop now.

Pointer: Maybe Prismagreen was right, but you don't need to improve this part. Just accept it as a ... personal trait. There's no need to torture Alia over it.

Hissabeth looks unconvinced. Yet to head off the inevitable argument, Pointer raises her glass, shifting the mood back to a well-timed toast.

Pointer: Let's raise a glass.

Pointer: To celebrate our project approval, and to our next reunion.

Kiperina: To the end of the "Storm."

Hissabeth: And to the stars.